

Debunking the Conservative “Paradox”: Conservative Identities and Narratives in Williamsburg, Virginia

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Introduction

“If we suppose that voters want, or should want, to use their power at the ballot box to advance their own economic fortunes or those of their fellow citizens, the fact that Republicans have won even a bare plurality of votes seems baffling” (Bartels, 2016, p. 74)

Political scientist Larry Bartels articulates a simple yet powerful idea: that conservative constituents in the United States are voting contrary to their economic interests. He voices concerns that those who vote for Republican candidates are supporting welfare cuts, regressive taxation, deregulation, and other policies that arguably disadvantage poor Americans. However, as Bartels points out, the Republican Party maintains a strong voter base of both wealthy and poor Americans alike. This is what many academics have identified as the “paradox” of conservatism; how can the Republican Party continue to garner votes when so many intrinsically conservative beliefs appear to hurt impoverished Americans? Bartels is not the only academic to wonder at this apparent “paradox”, nor is the wonderment confined to academia alone. Sociologist Katherine Cramer (Cramer 2016) questions “why, in times of increasing economic inequality, have the preferences of the lowest-income voters moved in a conservative, rather than liberal reaction?” Political analyst Thomas Frank (Frank 2004) asks why “so many Americans vote against their economic and social interests?” Even large news outlets such as the New York Times publish articles such as “Why the Working Class Votes Against Its Economic Interests?” (Madrick 2020). It can all be boiled down to one crude question: *Why* do Americans vote for Republicans?

Partisanship is increasingly related to a person's sense of self: they don't *vote* Republican, they *are* Republican (Greene et al. 2002; Iyengar et al. 2019). As such, parsing the *why* of conservatism necessitates more than survey based research. We can recognize with surveys that voters seem to hold beliefs contrary to their economic positions, but without speaking with them, we have no way of knowing what life experiences, ideals, or narratives cause this paradox. Yet, very few researchers on this topic have spoken at length with these voters. Two exceptions to this statement come from Sociologist Arlie Hochschild and political scientist Katherine Cramer, who each spent an extended amount of time in conservative communities getting to know the people there and their ways of life. These unique qualitative studies ultimately both argue that conservative voters' views are *not* paradoxical, but are justified by their unique perspectives and lifestyles. Each discusses the perspectives that appear to influence their participant's partisanship. I argue, similar to Hochschild and Cramer, that understanding partisanship as a part of personal identity is crucial to making sense of this “conservative paradox.”

In this study, I spent several hours each with conservative voters in James-City County, Virginia. Together, we discuss their lives, their economic views, and their political views. In doing so, I hoped to gain a deeper understanding of the narratives that these voters employed to make sense of the world around them. Not only do I offer evidence from both literature and my own work *against* the “paradox” of conservatism, but I also discover that Virginia offers unique insights into partisan conflict due to its geographic-partisan divides. I find that urban and rural identities significantly inform partisanship, adding a new dimension to how we define conservatism. Exploring the emotions that drive these voters is crucial to reaching across the aisle, encouraging empathy, and understanding those who differ from us, particularly in a time when partisan polarization is rapidly increasing.

In the following sections, I provide an overview of the relationship between wealth, class, and partisanship, as well as an understanding of how narratives can influence voting behavior. I go on to consider how opinions on economic opportunity, inequality, and participants' own experiences help us parse the conservative paradox, which leads me to a discussion of the ways Northern Virginia plays a key role in defining the political landscape of Virginia. I also explore the ways in which my participants feel sincere disrespect aimed at them from the inhabitants of Northern Virginia. I also consider the quiet influence of race on all these topics, and ultimately discuss the power this type of research has to mitigate partisan polarization through empathy and understanding across partisan divides.

Wealth, Class, and Conservative Narratives

If the conservative paradox is fundamentally based on a contradiction between voting trends and economic circumstances, it is important to understand the relationship between partisanship and wealth. On one hand, if wealth has no bearing on political leaning, it is understandable that someone may vote “against” their economic condition (for instance, a wealthy individual who supports raising taxes on the rich because they do not consider the consequences to their own economic status as a result). On the other hand, if there *is* some relationship, someone could indeed support policies *despite* their economic stratification (someone on welfare who votes to reduce social security benefits not because they ignore the bearing on their economic outcomes, but in spite of it).

We can easily set aside the argument that voting is mutually exclusive of wealth; there is truth to two related narratives. First, that Republicans represent the rich and Democrats the poor, and second, that wealthy states vote for Democrats while poor ones vote for Republicans. That both these statements can be true is at first confusing, and the typical red and blue patchwork maps that are often circulated during election cycles turn out to be an oversimplification of these trends. Consideration must be made for *how strongly* rich voters support Republicans in any given state: voters in rich states support Democrats even though, within any given state, rich voters support Republicans. This pattern is strongest in poor, rural states and weakest in rich urban ones. In essence, rich voters in poor states are more likely to support Republicans than rich

voters in rich states (Gelman et al. 2008). These patterns of partisanship have become increasingly stratified by income, where wealthy constituents are much more likely to vote Republican (McCarty, Pool, and Rosenthal, 2016). Though this simple, bivariate relationship between partisanship and income does not necessarily indicate causality, neither study was able to entirely explain the relationship by race, education, gender, religion, or any other third factor. This implies that economic circumstance has some influence on partisanship.

If the claim that wealth and partisanship are exclusive of one another does not hold up to scrutiny, then someone could, in theory, vote against their economic interests. This begs the question at the heart of the conservative paradox, *why*? It is true that the Democratic Party has lost many white southern voters, and popular media sources perpetuate the claim that Democrats now represent the “smug”, “condescending” elites and Republicans the average American (Rensin, 2016). However, this *Backlash* theory—the claim that class basis for partisan voters has inverted on the grounds of cultural issues, popularized by Thomas Frank’s *What’s the Matter with Kansas*—has not held up to empirical scrutiny (Brewer and Stonecash 2001; Gelman 2007; Nicholson and Segura 2012). If Frank’s Backlash theory does not accurately capture the apparent shift in voting trends and intensifying conservative ideology across the nation, then what does? What might cause a voter to overlook their own economic interests? Bartels (2008) attempts to tackle this question head on. The political scientist shows that inequality increases more under republican administrations than under democratic ones as a direct result of policy differences, meaning that wealthy voters experience the most income growth under Republicans. He also argues that voters are particularly sensitive to the economic fortunes of the rich. It follows that if voters are economically biased towards the wealthy, they may continue to support conservative politicians, even if they themselves do not benefit. Interestingly, both Gelman and McCarthy also point out the influence of elite and wealthy individuals on voting trends. The cross state trends that Gelman articulates show that the difference between voting patterns in rich and poor states is greatest for high-income voters, and McCarty attributes the increasing income-partisan stratification to an increased correlation between income and partisanship, which can be accounted for “by the actions of the party elites”. Perhaps, then, the answer to *why* is based on voters' conceptions of the elite and wealthy. Maybe poor voters are reacting to the actions of the wealthy.

This difference between poor and wealthy Americans—inequality—does provide a useful lens for considering partisanship and economic circumstance as both a politicized and individual phenomenon. In *The Undeserving Rich*, Leslie McCall (McCall 2013) identifies that sentiments towards big business and the rich are correlated with concerns about income inequality. McCall finds that someone's negative feelings towards the wealthy increases their concern about income inequality, while feelings about other social classes do not produce the same effect. She also argues that Americans are not necessarily concerned with the overall level of inequality, but with its effect on equitable growth. That is, Americans consider the “function and fairness of inequality”; if neighbors do not experience the same economic growth, that is when concerns about inequality grow. Not only is this perspective of inequality yet again related to the

wealthiest constituents, but it is also fundamentally based on contemporaneous comparison between individuals—Americans measuring their own status relative to those around them. We can posit that Americans often measure themselves in this way against the rich, given how much space they seem to occupy in the national consciousness. These comparisons are unlikely based simply on objective wealth, but also on subjective class. Though on a superficial level, terms like poor, middle class, and upper class may refer to income and wealth, as early as the 1950s, social scientists argued that class-based stratification incorporates subjective lifestyle ideals. Americans have an intuitive understanding of the hierarchy of class terms such as *poor*, *working*, *middle*, and *upper class*, and that the hierarchy is based on more than objective economic fact: it takes into account occupation, skill, and authority. In other words, class is as much subjectively socialized as it is objective (Jackman 1979). So, voters are reacting to the wealthiest Americans while also comparing their class to those around them.

I emphasize these facts about income inequality, perceptions of the wealthy, and subjective social class to argue that more than just objective wealth or income influences how Americans think about economics, and by extension, how it may impact their partisanship. The American dream—which so many refer to regarding economic policy—is not just about income, but class. The two-story house, the white picket fence, these are symbols of the suburban, middle class lifestyle. So, when considering the relationship between economic circumstance and partisanship, socioeconomic class provides a better theoretical baseline than income or wealth alone. A natural next step is to wonder *how* perceptions of the wealthy and class conflict might influence partisanship. Are these perceptions the answer to *why* Americans might vote contrary to their economic circumstance?

Katherine Cramer and Arlie Hochschild seem to think yes, they might be part of the puzzle. Cramer's *The Politics of Resentment* (Cramer 2016) and Hochschild's *Strangers in their Own Land* (Hochschild 2016) offer tangible examples of how cross-class comparison can influence someone's political perspectives. Both authors begin with the same question I am considering here: why might someone support policies that harm them, or in the least do not support policies that have the potential to benefit them? To answer this question, Cramer speaks with rural, conservative constituents across Wisconsin while Hochschild gets to know the Americans living in Lake Charles, Louisiana. Each discusses the perspectives that appear to influence their participant's partisanship. Hochschild depicts what she calls the "Deep Story" of conservative voters, while Cramer draws on group theory and uses the term "Rural Consciousness" in a similar fashion. Both theories are rooted in class, and Cramer also notes how class intersects with geographical location.

After spending 5 years immersed in the conservative community in Lake Charles, Louisiana, Hochschild (2016) lays out the *deep story* of these conservative supporters—the "story feelings tell...[that] permits those on both sides of the political spectrum to stand back and explore the *subjective prism* through which the party on the other side sees the world" (pg 135). In simpler terms, she attempts to explain the feelings of her participants that ultimately influence their conservative perspectives. With an extended metaphor, she explains that many Americans

feel as though they are waiting in a never-ending-line to reach the American Dream. And while they wait in this line, women, immigrants, and people of color skip ahead, often *aided* by the government. Hochschild explains that “one can see the experience of being “cut in on” by one group after another as an expression of class conflict” (pg 148). While the American Dream represents, at its core, *progress*, it is harder and harder to achieve. Progress has become “more chancy and more restricted to a small elite” with “the first generation in American history to experience... lifetime downward mobility (pg 141)” hitting their middle-ages. This inability to achieve economic mobility, despite it being core to the American consciousness, fuels resentment, anger, dejection, and according to Hochschild, moves constituents to the right ideologically.

Cramer (2016) builds on this story to explore how this “expression of class conflict” and perception of injustice manifests. Specifically, she details the identity that rural, conservative voters express in contrast to those who might be “cutting” in Hochschild’s line. She calls this identity the *Rural Consciousness*, “a perspective rooted in place and class identities that convey a strong sense of distributive injustice” (pg 15). The fundamental perspectives of the rural consciousness are that rural areas are overlooked by policy-makers, that they do not get their share of resources, and that they are misunderstood or disrespected by non-rural residents. In more overarching themes, these rural, conservative voters feel powerless, they feel relative deprivation, and they feel disrespected. Cramer shows how these perceptions can influence someone’s ideas about political issues by probing attitudes towards her home institution of the University of Wisconsin. She finds that signifiers of a rural perspective are also indicative of resentment towards the University, which is itself part of a broader resentment towards public institutions and employees. On a larger scale, she demonstrates how the rural consciousness “makes wanting less government a commonsense desire”.

So what can all this tell us about the conservative paradox? McCarty, Gelman, and Bartels each provide evidence *against* “persistent confusion about the role of class in the American electoral process” (Gelman, 2008, pg 176). Given the subtlety of income voting trends in the states, both Gelman and McCarty ultimately reject the claim that conservative voters “ignore” or “vote against their economic interests”, instead showing that “The divide between red and blue America looks different in different places and among different groups”. Bartels goes so far as to describe *why* someone may vote conservative despite their own economic conditions by demonstrating how voters can have short political memories and be more focused on those stratified above them than on themselves. Hochschild and Cramer take a different approach to the question, but come up with similar answers. They each demonstrate how conceptions of class conflict influence conservative voter’s perspectives. More importantly, they show that the stories people tell themselves, the narratives they use to understand the world around them, are crucial to unpacking political ideology. Hochschild argues that, when people feel as though they are being unfairly pushed to the back of the line when it comes to economic mobility, it is oftentimes easier to blame the government rather than admit the American Dream may be inherently flawed and their hard work meaningless. Cramer similarly shows that rural,

conservative residents are responsive to feelings of powerlessness and disrespect from urban centers that lean liberal, garnering distrust and resentment towards them. Each of these narratives makes supporting reduced government—the cornerstone of conservatism—feel like the natural answer. Possibly the conservative paradox is not such a paradox after all, but a reasonable response to the experiences of conservative voters.

Methods

I set out to explore this possibility within the Tidewater region of Virginia. I wondered how right-wing Virginians conceptualized the economic landscape of Virginia. Where do they see themselves fitting into Virginia's economic stratification? How do conceptions of class conflict and economic inequality inform the narratives they create? To what extent do these factors influence or stem from their political alignment? I ask these questions in an attempt to better understand the subjective economic realities and lived experiences of conservative Virginians, as well as the meaning-making that develops their conservative beliefs. Overall, do conservative constituents of Williamsburg, Virginia seem to fit into the conservative paradox? Or perhaps Hochschild and Cramer's theories apply beyond the regions they worked in to small communities such as my own. I conducted in-depth interviews with several conservative constituents of Williamsburg, Virginia to begin answering these questions.

Williamsburg proves to be an interesting location to research these topics. The city itself is wealthy compared to much of Virginia, and is predominantly white (US Census, 2020). The College of William & Mary contributes to this difference, as much of the student body is white and comes from highly privileged backgrounds. However, Williamsburg is also situated between Newport News, Norfolk, and Richmond, all racially diverse localities with variable levels of wealth. Even driving half an hour west of the city takes one into towns such as Toano, where the agricultural industry dominates and the feeling is much more rural. Within Williamsburg, many gated communities hide exorbitant homes and wealthy families, while apartment complexes and trailer parks are only a few minutes down the road. While the city may not compare to the kind of riches found in northern counties of Virginia, it is certainly home to a wide range of wealth, of which my participants were well aware.

When it came to finding participants, my intent was to conduct a snowball sample beginning in local conservative community groups. However, I was met with resistance and many of the people I spoke with were skeptical, if not downright dismissive of my work. My association with the College of William & Mary, even as a student, was off putting. I received questions like “Why does the university care what I think? What will they do with my information?” One particularly resistant community member stated outright that he saw William & Mary as a “liberal cesspool” that “indoctrinates” its students. My understanding of this overarching skepticism is that it came from fears of being misrepresented. I came to learn that a few of these community groups had worked with media outlets in the past that had been less than kind to their memberships, so I understood their frustration and even fearfulness.

This skepticism that I encountered in gaining access to this community is representative of a wider mistrust between conservative voters and academic institutions. Cramer found the similar attitudes when speaking to rural residents of Wisconsin. She shows that perceptions about universities and public institutions as a whole are informed by feelings of misunderstanding and disrespect. While I am not able to report on this within my own pool of participants, it is important to recognize that those who declined to participate are not merely acting antagonistic towards higher education institutions as they are often portrayed to be. In the least, the resistance I faced shaped the pool of participants I had access to, and at most it represented a culture of mistrust across entire swaths of the American public.

Over the course of this research, I met with multiple conservative community groups in Williamsburg, Virginia, and got to know many of their members and leadership. I am thankful that a few influential community members placed their trust in me and allowed me to speak with them and their memberships. After assuring them that their participation was confidential and that the university has no ulterior motives (and that this project was primarily for my own intellectual curiosity and academic career), I found that my participants were extremely willing to speak with me at length, came to interviews curious and open-minded, and expressed interest and even hopefulness at the prospect of having their perspectives represented. In the end, I spoke with six members of the Williamsburg conservative community, five of whom were men, and one woman. Their ages ranged from 27 to 77, and their life experiences ranged from work in the fast food industry to years spent in the military to time spent teaching at prestigious private schools. While the small pool of participants I ended up with may not necessarily be representative of the wider conservative community in Virginia, or even Williamsburg itself, their stories are worth hearing. In fact, I argue that representativeness is not the main goal of this work, but rather deep engagement with people's lived experiences is. Indeed, every person I spoke with, skeptical or not, indicated that they were surprised at my interest in their community. I got the impression that for many of them, no one had indicated such in-depth interest in their thoughts, let alone someone so different from them as a young, liberal, sociology student from the northeast with a nose ring.

The names in this report are pseudonyms, and certain quotations have been altered slightly to maintain anonymity for my participants. Otherwise, the quotations I have selected to share come directly from my 20 hours of interviewing, unaltered. In the next sections, I detail several overarching themes that came out of these interviews. I begin by contextualizing the landscape of Virginia geographically, politically, and economically, and explore how these facts influence my participants' understanding of their partisanship. I find that, more than direct economic fact, a sense of non-urban identity and partisan disrespect informs the narratives that my participants detail. And while these narratives may not be exclusive of race, they are also not entirely explained by race alone. These findings mimic Cramer and Hochschild's own, implying that their theories can be broadly applied beyond the communities they studied, while also emphasizing the importance of personal narratives, identities, and qualitative field-work when researching individual decisions and beliefs.

Economic Values

“A lot of Virginians are willing to spend money, particularly when it's not their money.”

To approach the conservative paradox from the ground up, I began by asking participants questions about their own economic experiences. Though Williamsburg, compared to much of the rest of the state, is fairly wealthy, my participants represented a range of backgrounds. Some grew up poor for their time, and some stated they have never felt economically insecure. Some identified themselves as upper middle class, some felt they led a fairly average lifestyle, and some were reliant on family members to stay afloat. Several described fluctuations in their economic status, resulting from job loss, medical bills, or other unforeseen circumstances. Despite their unique experiences, our conversations often led us to the same topics. Many were concerned about where their tax money was being spent, and on who. Particular attention was given to talk of welfare, and whether the people receiving it had “earned” it. This view—dislike towards large government spending, particularly from constituents tax dollars—is not groundbreaking, but a cornerstone of conservative politics. Trey articulates these traditional viewpoints well.

Rebecca: So if I asked about income inequality or wealth inequality, can you speak to what those terms mean to you and how you might see that manifesting in Virginia?

Trey: Yeah, uh. I kinda wince with that whole... how that's being discussed these days. Yes, there's disparity. There's people making less than a thousand a month and there's people making a hundred thousand a month, in the Northern Virginia area, Tidewater area. There's... and it has to be dealt with. There's a big drive for subsidized housing. To try to give men and women and families who are struggling, give them a leg up so they can be closer to the towns and education and good jobs and medical care. Um... but... it seems to me that it's become excessive. Because what used to happen is people would work hard and be disciplined, and they would get a job and stick with it, and they would advance that way without asking for government help. And I think the more the government helps with welfare, very high levels of welfare where you get the... where people can actually, some people can actually stay home and work and make more money that way than making a low paying job. That's not good. That kind of dependency I think is growing, and it's a culture [...] [conservatives] believe there should be equal opportunity, not equity. Equality, not equity. The movements to provide, the movements to just give money to people and families so they have more money so that it's closer to the middle class is not right. There should be a trade. Okay, we'll give you money, we'll give you welfare, but you have to do this this and this [...] I get the feeling that the liberals are buying votes by doing that.

Trey points out a few key things. First, he expresses concern about income and wealth inequality, particularly in the northern region of Virginia versus the rest of the state. Nearly all of my participants agreed that *something* needed to be done about inequality. However, in Trey's case, he disagrees with what he sees as handouts to those who are not working for it. He describes that people need to work hard and be disciplined—in essence, the age-old “pull yourself up by your bootstraps” trope, which states that Americans are able to provide for themselves through hard work and perseverance. When I asked him, and other participants, whether they had experienced economic insecurity, they often alluded to this ideal and how they performed it in their own lives.

Rebecca: Has there ever been a time in your life when you felt economically insecure?

Trey: Uh... [*long pause*]... the only time I got a little bit close to that is when I got laid off by [my company]. And that was a short amount of time. Just a few weeks, I started getting nervous. But then I started looking at my situation, and I said, wait a minute, you've just been shocked, So you're not insecure, you've got a great education, I know computers and software, and all I need to do is go out and pound the pavement like I used to do when I was a salesman, and I'll find a good job.

While Trey emphasized that he just needed to “pound the pavement”, other participants had more extreme experiences. James recalls filing for bankruptcy:

Rebecca: So has there ever been a time in your life when you felt economically insecure.

James: Oh, baby [...] [We had] medical bills. And bills coming in. And the prescriptions. And private school, so on and so on. We went bankrupt. I know what it's like to have no money. I get it. And it still remained difficult after that because the bills were still there, coming in. And we were not making that kind of money... But I'm a persistent son of a gun. We did go under then again. Which was awful.

James describes himself as a “persistent son of a gun”, once again calling on the bootstraps ideal, where he just needed to work hard and get through it. This kind of belief in the ability for anyone to pull themselves up by their bootstraps typically led my participants to a discussion of welfare. If anyone truly can support themselves with a little hard work, it follows that those who are asking for assistance simply aren't working hard enough, while their welfare draws on the incomes of those who are.

Trey: The big dilemma nationwide is what do you do with the unmotivated? With those that just don't see the opportunities, or if they see them they say that's not for me, I'd

rather sit at home. That's really tough, but the... I just think the opportunities are there, big government handouts just discourage people from being adults frankly.

Not all of my participants expressed this sentiment so blatantly, if at all, but I believe it is important to point out as an example of the role *opportunity* plays in understanding economic topics such as inequality. Leslie McCall (2013) describes that in the bootstrap world, views about economic equality are secondary to views on opportunity. That is, so long as everyone has the opportunity to work hard enough, economic outcomes are not institutionally unequal, but result from individual choices: “Americans are held responsible for their station in life precisely because job opportunities are perceived as plentiful” (pg 145)

William: I'm very much a Milton Friedman person, where everyone begins at the same place, and what we can't guarantee is that everyone will end at the same place, but that everyone has an equal opportunity to get there. So there's a huge difference between legislating equality, versus access to the tools that you need in order to—

Rebecca: So you're speaking a little bit about opportunity.

William: Right. I definitely think that regardless, for Virginia or anywhere else, I think that opportunities are much more available to a much wider set of the population. I think the community college system has been a great institution to help high school seniors make that transition into the work world where so many professions you really just need an associate degree.

William exemplifies here not only the importance of opportunities, but the weight that education holds when considering these opportunities, seconded by Peter.

Peter: And, to use the word opportunities again, this time referring to, okay are there jobs open for these people. Can we help these people fit into jobs or learn a skill that they didn't have, and how do we reach these communities? And then, to bring it back to the conservative view, how do we do that without costing taxpayers an absolute fortune and particularly overburdening people who are not making a lot of money to begin with? Because, you know, one of the reasons I'm fairly conservative is having been in the military and observing plenty of ridiculously wasteful spending. I try to be mindful of where we are getting the money to pay for this.

The conservative paradox is based on the idea that poor Americans who need support are not voting for politicians who offer it. My participants are not these poor Americans—they are all relatively financially stable, if not wealthy. I also cannot claim that their views are representative of the entire conservative community. On the surface, they are concerned about how the

government is spending money, especially the money that they pay in taxes. Often, they feel as though *too much* money is being spent, and that those who receive welfare don't necessarily deserve it. But on a deeper level, they are considering the distribution of opportunities such as education and engaging with a narrative of fairness in economics. It is not *fair* that Americans who do not work are receiving welfare from those who do. Hochschild finds the same in her work with conservatives who *are* impoverished; "Government checks for the listless and idle—this seems most unfair," she states, explaining how her participants display contempt for those below them on the economic ladder (Hochschild, 2021).

This discussion of economics alone does not support or disprove the conservative paradox directly, but it does give us insight into some of the values that inform conservative voters. In my participants' case, hard work, fairness, and education are all discussed repeatedly. Many indicate that inequality *is* a problem, but do not condone fixing it in ways that violate these values. Interestingly, these values come into play throughout all of our discussions, not just when I probe for economic viewpoints specifically. Most notably, a conception of fairness within the economic landscape of Virginia led me to realize that not just individual economic circumstance informs partisanship, but an understanding of regional economics within the state also comes into play, particularly with respect to northern Virginia.

Contextualizing Northern Virginia

"We are nothing, nothing, compared to northern Virginia"

Of the 10 wealthiest counties in the United States by median household income, four are located in the most northern part of Virginia—Loudoun County, Falls Church, Fairfax County, and Arlington County. The top two counties by income in the country (Loudoun and Falls Church) have a median income over \$15,000 greater than the following third county (Santa Clara, California). Comparatively, the median household income for the entire state of Virginia is only a little over half of the income in Loudoun and Falls Church. These northern counties have some of the highest population densities in the state, with Arlington capping it off at over 9,000 residents per square mile. They have also seen the most population growth in the last 10 years, with up to a 34% increase in Loudoun County (US Census, 2020). This income, population, and growth disparity has led Northern Virginia to be viewed as so different from other regions of the state that it is often colloquially referred to as "NoVa".

It is also commonly understood that Northern Virginia consists of the largest democratic voter base in the state, supplemented by other urban areas and independent cities such as Richmond, Norfolk, and Roanoke. In 2016, Democratic presidential candidate Hillary Clinton won Virginia with 49.73% of the popular vote, despite winning only 40 of Virginia's 134 counties and cities (29.85%). Of these 40, a large portion of votes came from Fairfax, Prince William, Loudoun, Arlington, and other northern counties. Similarly, in the recent 2021 governor's race, Republican candidate Glenn Youngkin only won by about 60,000 votes (2%)

despite winning the large majority of Virginia's counties and cities. Of course, these statistics follow a nation-wide correlation between population density and partisanship; dense, urban areas are more likely to vote democratic, while low-density, rural communities trend conservative. This trend drives a wedge between geographically and politically differing communities, and it is no different in Virginia.

The first thing to recognize about these statistics is that they are much more than that to many residents of Virginia. They are salient realities and dictate perceptions of Virginia's political landscape. Every participant I spoke with conceptualized Northern Virginia in nearly the same way. In some instances, I asked participants directly about the region, while in others I asked them to describe Virginia and conversation of "NoVa" arose naturally. In either sense, the concept of Northern Virginia occupies a large space in Virginia's state-wide consciousness. William anecdotally explained this to me in one of my first interviews.

Rebecca: I'm also curious about this idea of Northern Virginia being its own region. Do you know anything, can you elaborate on how you think NoVa is maybe different from the rest of the state, what it's like...?

William: Okay, 15 or 20 years ago, you may know there's a thing called Northern Virginia Community College, and it's referred to as NoVa. And it's got several campuses, "NoVa at, at, at". So that term NoVa became a fairly generic term for anything inside the beltway or out into the outer suburbs. And somebody that didn't live in NoVa said "okay, well I live in RoVa," which stands for the *rest* of Virginia.

As William describes, Northern Virginia is repeatedly construed as the antithesis to the entire rest of Virginia, or RoVa. For this reason, beyond being a superficial regional label, the term NoVa implies almost an entirely different state. Other participants corroborated this sentiment:

Rebecca: So what would you... how would you describe the state then to someone who's not from Virginia or hasn't been here as long? What would you tell them about it?

James: What would I tell them about it... [pauses] I think there's two, there's two states within one. There's Northern Virginia and everybody else. The rest of the state is, I think, fairly conservative.

This distinction between NoVa and RoVa is not made without good reason. As already described, there are unmistakable economic and partisan divides between the regions that are meaningful to many constituents. James' quick, unprompted transition from the regional divide to politics shows how unified regional identity is with partisanship. The implication here is that while the rest of the state is "fairly conservative", Northern Virginia is anything but. This sense of regional partisanship is also very closely coupled with feelings of powerlessness when it

comes to political decision making. That is, participants perceived that their local communities held much less power than communities in Northern Virginia.

Rebecca: So, something that, when I came here for school, people immediately started talking about “NoVa”.

Tracy: Northern Virginia.

Rebecca: Yes. And that's something that... [*pauses*] kind of conceptually, why does it have a different name? What can you tell me about NoVa? Maybe in relation to what we've been talking about. [*population, income, taxes, etc*]

Tracy: Um, I don't know a lot about Richmond, it's included in that as well, right? So, the guy I dated before my husband, his parents lived up in Fort Lauderdale, which is up in Northern Virginia. Now, we've been talking about this part of Virginia [Tidewater], we are nothing, *nothing*, compared to northern Virginia.

[...]

So it's interesting that Northern Virginia, you know, is the deciding factor.

[...]

Rebecca: Do you... can you speak a little about that? How does it manifest?

Tracy: I mean, every single time in any voting thing, it's always... [*pauses*] Fairfax is the deciding factor of the state. It's always like okay, we're waiting for Fairfax. It's always like, if we're going ahead in Republican, that's when it crashes 'casue they are the deciding part of the state.

The phenomenon that Tracy is referring to here does happen often in Virginia. As county votes are tallied and reported, the state initially appears very conservative, with red sweeping from the south-western part of the state all the way to the south-eastern corner. However, conservative hopes are dashed as votes from Northern Virginia are counted—the northern liberal powerhouse swings the pendulum back to the left. Conservative voters in the state have come to expect this story every time: many participants noted pleasant surprise at Glenn Youngkin's gubernatorial win in 2021.

But simply because constituents expect this pattern of voting doesn't mean they view it as fair. In fact, my participants expressly state that it is *unfair*, even undemocratic. In our discussions, I sensed thinly veiled bewilderment and anger at the perceived meaninglessness of their votes.

William: And I do think that is... now again, I'll give you my politics up front. Election night for governor, this past election night, of course the Richmond channels and other local—that is by Virginia—TV channels were carrying results live. And late in the evening, 10 or 11 o'clock, they put a map up. And of course [*gestures*] red, blue. Red for all the localities, and there were like three pockets of blue: NoVa, around the Richmond urban area, and Tidewater. And the *entire* rest of the state was red! *Everything else lit up was red.* And Younkin won, what, 51- 49?

William's shock at the narrow margin with which Younkin won, despite the near homogeneous red of the county map exemplifies this feeling. While Northern Virginia is a small subsection of the state, it appears to have at least as much, if not more, voting power as the entire rest of Virginia. Of course, we know that NoVa is much more populated, which causes a large number of votes to be concentrated in the small region. But this knowledge does not undermine the fact that it *feels* like NoVa's votes are worth more, that they hold more *power* to influence political decision making.

William: You do realize what a stark distinction there is between all of that wealth and voting power that's located in 5 or 6 counties around DC, Loudoun county, Fauquier county, Fairfax, Arlington, versus everywhere else across the state except Richmond and Tidewater. So I do think there's a schism between Northern Virginia

Rebecca: So, thinking economically in the state, do you think that the divide also exists in an economic world or—

William: Definitely. I think the voting power in Northern Virginia takes all the air out of the room when it comes to highway development and schools

This comment about highway development and schools is indicative of an important dimension to political power: the ability to control what issues get discussed. The geographical and density differences between Northern Virginia and the Tidewater Region naturally leads to different concerns. But the voting power of Northern Virginia is perceived to override any concerns that non-rural Virginia has.

Peter: with the economic divide between northern virginia and the southwest, there's definitely some hard feelings.

Rebecca: Can you elaborate on that a little bit for me?

Peter: [...] There are large parts of the south and western state that do not have modern infrastructure. Particularly digital infrastructure. Health services aren't there either. Once you get west of 81 it's got nothing like the healthcare that's in the rest of the state. So it's

interesting, Democrats trying to run on hey you know, improving healthcare infrastructure and all that in the south and western part of the states and trying to make inroads on conservative communities there and being told to pound sand because the folks there are like, okay yes we want that stuff but we don't want it from you.

It is tempting to let this sentiment—that southern Virginians *want* updated infrastructure, just not from Democrats—lead us back to the original paradox. If these voters are being offered what they want, why don't they take it? But if you were offered a gift from an untrustworthy neighbor, would you take it? Northern Virginia Democrats don't understand the unique lifestyles of rural Virginia, so they can't be trusted to deliver what those voters really need. And even worse, much of Northern Virginia's population isn't really from Virginia.

Peter: [...] Because Northern Virginia has a disproportionate—not only is the income disproportionately high, it's disproportionately educated, and disproportionately transplants. Huge number of people in Northern Virginia aren't from here.

Rebecca: Is that part of the animosity?

Peter: 100%. Yes it is. One of the big repeated attacks on Northern Virginia's political power in the state is the number of people they tend to elect who are not from Virginia. And that particularly tends to rub people the wrong way who are from the southwest or from south central Virginia.

Rebecca: I get that, that would piss me off too.

Peter: Yes, people whose families have been here since as long as there's been white settlement in this part of the world are looking at a transplant from New York or California. Like, what the hell are you doing in my state? Particularly when that person comes in with political ideas that are either unfamiliar or opposed to what they believe. It's like, who the hell are you to come into my state and try to tell me what to do? Particularly with so much, because you know money is power in politics, with how much wealth is concentrated in Northern Virginia, makes it very difficult for the rest of the state to compete.

Who are you to come into my state and try to tell me what to do? It is true that Northern Virginia has seen the most population growth in the last 10 years of the entire state. Participants repeat the claim that many of these people are “transplants”, people moving to the state from other parts of the county, particularly the northeast. So when the Democratic Party is electing these transplants, how can they be trusted to represent the interests of a true Virginian? The economic gap between NoVa and RoVa only intensifies this feeling, when wealth is almost synonymous with power.

The perception seems to be that NoVa has all this political power in part *because* of its immense wealth. We can see this in the way participants reference the two together—Peter states plainly that “money is power in politics”. It is curious to imagine whether the divides would be so deep if NoVa was not so much wealthier than the aggregate of RoVa—would the population difference then hold more salience for non-urban voters? But then, the issue of “transplants” still remains.

The conflict being expressed here boils down to an age-old Urban-Rural divide in the United States. The story my participants tell is this: Northern Virginia is much more densely populated and much wealthier than the rest of the state. The region has experienced exponential economic growth, especially in highly paid industries often contracted by the federal government. This booming population includes wealthy government employees looking for a home outside of the city center. Also, taxes are lower in NoVa than in liberal northeastern states like New Jersey, Vermont, and Connecticut, so democratic voters relocate to the region. This causes Northern Virginia to act as a democratic powerhouse in both state and federal elections, overshadowing the rest of the non-urban and rural Virginia, where many constituents have never lived anywhere else in their entire lives. It *feels* as if NoVa is sitting on RoVa’s chest, constricting its airway and suffocating the cries of its residents. It’s no wonder that these voters are frustrated—this hardly seems fair when NoVa only represents a tiny geographic fraction of the state and is perceived to be made up of outsiders. We see here, again, how important it is that things feel *fair* to voters.

Important to understand is that we are not simply discussing *what* the regional divides are, but *how* these differences influence conservative identities in non-urban communities like Williamsburg. The data I present here shows that, even in a fairly suburban and wealthy locality such as Williamsburg, conservative voters feel as though they can’t match up to the political powerhouse that is Northern Virginia. And when Northern Virginia is nearly synonymous with the Virginia Democratic Party, it seems as though Virginia Democrats are cheating at politics. We can see that this goes beyond simple awareness of lifestyle and economic differences, and bleeds into the “feels-as-if” realm of politics. An application of Katherine Cramer’s Rural Consciousness is useful here; my participants check all the boxes Cramer proposes. They feel as though rural Virginia is overlooked by policy-makers who are not responsive to their unique needs. They feel as though political power is not fairly distributed and is instead concentrated in Northern Virginia. They express conflict rooted in class divides and distributive injustice, based on the extreme wealth of NoVa. And while these facts cause frustration, anger, and resentment themselves, I will next show that participants also feel a deep sense of disrespect from Virginia Democrats.

Partisan Disrespect

Adjacent to the conservative paradox is the implication that rich Americans have shifted towards the Democratic Party. While we’ve already shown that this claim does not hold up to

empirical scrutiny, the narrative of “smug”, “condescending” Democrats continues to perpetuate political media. There are several reasons it may be gaining popularity. For one, a “diploma divide” between white voters with a college degree and those without has led those with formal higher education to lean left on the political spectrum, leading the media to extrapolate that conservative voters are simply less educated. Another popular argument is exemplified in Thomas Frank’s popular *What’s the Matter with Kansas*. Frank argues that working-class voters are “distracted” by cultural issues such as abortion and gun rights, which tricks them into voting against their economic interests. This claim paints these conservative voters as lacking critical thought, or easily coerced. Neither of these narratives creates a flattering portfolio of the conservative voter base, something that my participants are very well aware of. I asked them broadly to describe Democratic voters in the state of Virginia, and many responded not by discussing policy, but by emphasizing a sense of disrespect.

William: I think [conservatives] feel that [liberals] have—certainly evangelists, but other people that have a faith and they go to church—that’s not necessarily a liberal viewpoint, and they maybe would think that they are uneducated or not sophisticated. I mean Hillary, when she said the deplorables, that may have done more to sink her—

Rebecca: You mean liberals have this view point?

William: I think that liberals would look at conservative people with conservative viewpoints and say that... you know, the Walmart, the deplorables, that’s what she’s saying! Go to Walmart, see all those deplorables. And she had a hard time walking that back.

What William is describing is the instance where presidential candidate Hillary Clinton described half of Donald Trump’s voter base as “deplorable”. But beyond being a conviction of just Clinton, William describes the conservative feeling that liberals as a whole view conservative voters as “uneducated” and “not sophisticated”. There is, predictably, some animosity based on inherent lifestyle divisions in urban and non-urban lifestyles. Trey describes a very typical feeling that urbanites are simply less friendly than their rural counterparts:

Rebecca: You called DC unfriendly, can you elaborate on that?

[...]

Trey: It’s extremely diverse. My naturally friendly demeanor was rejected all the time [...] But yeah, so it was sad, because even though it was diverse, I actually felt like I wasn’t accepted [...] the hustle bustle up there, the stress, makes people unfriendly in casual settings.

However, the personal divides run much deeper. Not only do Americans increasingly disagree on policy issues, but they also increasingly dislike and distrust any members of the opposite political party (Iyengar et al. 2019). My participants felt this trend personally.

Rebecca: Can you.. I know it's maybe not your group, but describe Democrats in the area? What are their stances, what are they like? People you've met...

Tracy: They're evil towards Republicans, I'll tell you that. I think they're very strong in their beliefs, whatever their beliefs are. Anything Republican, they want the opposite of. Everybody's belief is different about abortion, that is a deciding factor on some of these things. I don't know what their beliefs are.. I tend to vote Republican.

Rebecca: What makes you say they're evil towards Republicans, can you give any experiences?

Tracy: Anybody who's a Democrat doesn't necessarily hate Republican people, they just automatically want to sway you towards their belief. And I think if you believe Republican or independent, or whatever, I'm not going to try and sway a Democrat because they're not going to [...] I think Republicans tend to be more laid back and stuff, but [Democrats] tend to be like "this is what I believe in and you're an idiot".

[...]

Rebecca: Have you had experiences like that with Democrats?

Tracy: Yes, I have a friend who's a staunch Democrat, and during Obama, oh yes, everything's good. Obama won two elections! I didn't go, "Oh my god, I hate you". That's your opinion, you won, you won two back to back things. And what? Trump won? They lost their ever loving minds. They were bashing and bashing and bashing.

Clearly, my participants are aware of the narrative that they are uneducated "idiots", as Tracy states. Perhaps not all Democrats believe this, but my participants have experienced it enough that the narrative is significant to them. Who wouldn't feel disrespected when hearing these things about yourself? In politics, the implication is that conservative voters are not educated enough to be making political decisions in the first place.

William: [...] if you started in Florida, you could go all the way from Florida to Washington state and never leave red. There was a red corridor through the central part, what they call the fly over states. That's a pejorative way to look at the US, but that's the mindset. Along the east coast and along the west coast, they've got it all figured out. They

know what to do, and everybody else in between, we don't really care what you think. And the analogy in Virginia is the people in northern Virginia and the people in Richmond, they think “okay, we've got it figured out and we just want to tell the rest of you what to do. All you gotta do is listen to us and everything will be fine”.

Rebecca: So you're describing people telling you what to do, who are these people?

William: Well, Northam. And the Democrat congress and senate.

All you gotta do is listen to us and everything will be fine. Is this not the sentiment at the heart of the conservative paradox? Asking why someone votes against their economic interest implies knowledge about what their interests *should* be. According to my participants, they feel like Virginia Democrats are condescending, look down on conservative voters, and think they know better. Understanding these feelings rounds out the application of Cramer's Rural Consciousness to my data. My participants feel as though they are disrespected and that their unique lifestyles and experiences are misunderstood. And while my goal is not to dissect the truth behind these feelings, it is understandable that they would be frustrated and even downright angry at continually being overlooked and patronized. Consider also that much of Virginia's Democratic base is concentrated in Northern Virginia, which already dominates the state's political landscape. Adding a dimension of personal disrespect to the mix feels like they are being kicked while already down. These narratives only deepen partisan divides and foster resentment.

So far, I have demonstrated that Virginia can be conceptualized as two states within one: Northern Virginia, and everyone else. Comparing the two regions incorporates class conflict based on both objective and subjective factors; NoVa is much wealthier than the remainder of the state, and perpetuates a very different, urbanized lifestyle from other non-urban localities. Though many of my participants state they themselves are economically secure, even in the upper-middle class, it does not seem to compare to the extreme wealth they perceive to be concentrated in Northern Virginia. These realities also feel deeply unfair, which we've seen is important to my participants on a fundamental level. And to add to it, my participants feel personally disrespected as conservatives.

All this helps us to understand what feelings may influence conservative Virginian voters in non-urban communities. When the animosity towards liberal centers such as Northern Virginia is so high, no conservative wants to vote Democratically. Perhaps even more important, they feel that Democratic policy violates their values of hard work and fairness, key parts of their personal identities. As I am talking to my participants about their political views, these are the things that are emphasized. These feelings and narratives, rather than or in addition to political policy, guide their voting preferences. This, more than anything, seems to unravel the potential paradox and answer *why* someone may vote despite their economic status. In reality, instead of voting against themselves, they are voting for the values they believe in.

A Note on Race

Before concluding, I find it necessary to note that the divides that I am describing, between NoVa and RoVa, between wealthy and poor, happen to align with racial divides. Northern Virginia is much more diverse than Williamsburg, as most urban localities tend to be. When people are worried about their tax dollars going to welfare, who do they conceptualize as welfare recipients? This, too, is racialized. It would be negligent for me to discuss such topics without considering how race may inform my participants' stories. I never explicitly asked any participant about race (or even designed questions to target the topic). But, it continually came up in interviews. It became clear that participants repeatedly identified class with race in a pattern that couldn't be ignored. I found it notable which questions I asked prompted discussion of race. Repeatedly, it was questions about class and inequality, as well as discussion about Northern Virginia.

Rebecca: So besides the political stance, are there any other differences you see between [Northern Virginia and the rest of the state]?

James: I don't know much about Northern Virginia, except some of the politics I read about is uh... I think crazy. But you know, the uh, there's a... when you start getting outside the Williamsburg area and you start to get into some of these rural areas, it's a lot more uh, besides being rural, it's more insular, if you will.

Rebecca: Okay, like an in group out group type of—

James: Yeah... because they all know each other. There is a... I wouldn't say racial conflict, there's probably some... that's breaking down though. These, the white folks and the black folks, of course the biggest hour of the week for segregation is 11 in the morning on Sunday. But some of that breaking down, it's interesting [...] But if you watch the news, people are at each others throats. But in reality, people aren't. I don't know where they're getting all this stuff. But anyway, go ahead. Did that answer?

In attempting to describe for me the differences between Northern Virginia and the remainder of the state, James slipped into conversation about racial conflict. He argues that there is less conflict than many believe, but the point I want to make here is how these regional identities are tied to race. We've already seen how these identities are also tied to class, so it is no surprise when questions about class and inequality also conjure up thoughts about race. In one interview, the participant clearly equated race with class so extremely that I feel he may not have understood the definition of the terms:

William: “We've moved away from looking at people as individuals. I mean I think Martin Luther King, he was about individuals. Not a class of people. It's the content of your mind, it's not the color of your skin. The color of your skin is going to make you in a class. But it's the way you think that's going to make you an individual”

While this is an extreme example, and most participants did seem to have a strong grasp on race and class as concepts, they continued to inherently relate the two.

Rebecca: So if I asked you about the term inequality and economic inequality, how would you think about that in Virginia and define that?

Gary: I don't know how I define that off the top of my head. I think, I think inequality, there's work there, but I don't... if it's because of education or if it's because of experience or... I don't have a good feel for it, for what that means. I think if it's racial, I really don't have an opinion. I honestly believe if you want to work that you could. That's my opinion right now. And as far as everything I've read says to me that there—that the super sensitivity that we have regarding anything to do with discrimination should override any inequality as far as opportunity to be in business or anything else.

Rebecca: Can you elaborate on what you mean by that?

Gary: What I read tells me that the, for people of any gender, any race, color, whatever, uh, there are rules and laws that have been put in place to stop any discrimination in that basis. I don't think that if you wanted to do something that that would get in your way, I don't believe that, but if it's happening, it shouldn't, but I don't believe it is.

Gary stumbles through this portion of our conversation, and I would wager that he was uncomfortable discussing discrimination and race. It is clear that he is considering how opportunities may be racialized, whether or not he believes they are in reality. Again, these thoughts came up when I prompted participants to consider inequality. Trey adamantly promised me he was not racist when I asked about his financial status.

Rebecca: So, shifting gears a little bit. We talked about Virginia, and now a bit about you. Would you consider yourself a typical Virginian, in your financial status? Where do you fall, would you say?

Trey: Okay, I'm uh, I'm in the upper middle class. Educated, white traditional Virginian. Virginia gentleman. Sometimes I can slip into a good ol' boy attitude. I lived, Oklahoma to Texas to Georgia to North Carolina. I've always lived in the South. Except when I lived up 10 years in Maryland with my wife, 'cause that was her home. But my wife's

traditional, I mean that area up there, lots of Democrats. But she's more traditional, certainly not an excessive liberal. So, but, my father worked hard, I modeled after him [...] but I do have, I am certainly not a racist. I have many friends of different nationalities. My wife also is the same way. We travel, we vacation, we visit them. We don't talk about the different races. You know, we're americans. We talk about other things. I don't like when politicians, the media, starts going down identity politics [...]

It seems as though my prompting Trey about his class led him to discuss his fathers hard work, which then led to the discussion of race. Perhaps talk of hard work incited feelings about welfare and its perceived recipients?

The goal of this study was not to evaluate racial attitudes in my participants. However, the key conflict that I get at—Urban and Non-Urban divides—is in itself, tied up in racial conflict, as my participants demonstrate. I feel it is important to recognize this reality, but not to let it overshadow the complexity of this relationship. When talking about Northern Virginia, my participants also displayed animosity toward government employees and high-income constituents who are primarily white; the feelings associated with geographic divides are not simply due to racial resentment or segregation. They also incorporate what I've already discussed—partisan disrespect, economic values, and urban/non-urban conflict. However, it is important to know about the overlap between these themes and race, as an analysis of either would not be complete without both. Truly, each of the themes I have outlined are not distinct but, but are each tied to one another in practice.

Discussion

Admittedly, I initiated this project partially because I myself struggled to understand why someone would vote for the Republican Party. I knew what policy they pushed, and how the media portrayed them, but at the same time I had never spoken at length to anyone who identified as conservative. This is, in part, my own fault, as I carefully chose my social circle to reflect my own beliefs, as many of us do. But early in my preliminary research, I was exposed to this idea of the conservative paradox: Why would someone dependent on welfare vote for a politician who would reduce it? To me—and to many academics—this seemed downright paradoxical. And yet, in many discussions of the paradox, I found myself disliking the way conservative voters were characterized. The implication became that these voters didn't *know better*, they just didn't get it the way we liberal academics do. If only they were more knowledgeable, more sympathetic, more *something*, things would be different. Certainly, I thought, there was no way an entire swath of the American public was voting conservatively because they were, well, dumb.

This is where I began my work. With an understanding of the conservative paradox, and also with a vague feeling of wrongness surrounding it. I wanted to find out for myself what drove conservative voters, and see whether or not there was any truth to this paradox. Thankfully, I

found myself in a part of the United States well suited to these questions, where the state of Virginia is divided regionally both economically and politically. While I met some resistance within the conservative community of Williamsburg, I also was lucky to meet several community members that were willing to speak at length with me. This preliminary resistance was my first insight into the deep sense of distrust this community was harboring, a theme that would prove important over the course of my interviews. In the end, I collected 20 hours worth of qualitative data and set to work trying to understand what informed my participants' conservative identities, and whether or not they could offer any insight into the conservative paradox.

My participants, by nature of Williamsburg's general wealth, were not the low-income conservatives that would be voting to cut their own welfare. However, I was still able to discuss their economic experiences and gain initial insight into the values that guided their economic beliefs. While they all emphasized the importance of hard work (an unsurprising manifestation of the American belief that anyone can "pull themselves up by their bootstraps"), they also alluded more inadvertently to the importance of fairness in economic policy. The moments they expressed the most displeasure for politics or the economy was when it seemed unfair; people being rewarded for not working, Northern Virginia controlling so much of Virginia's political battle, these things feel like a violation of honest democracy. Indeed, the conception of Northern Virginia as a political powerhouse became arguably the most important finding of my work. Though I knew superficially that the region was much more urbanized than Williamsburg—and certainly western Virginia—I was surprised to find how much influence this fact held in the minds of my participants. Repeatedly, I was told how wealthy and powerful Northern Virginia truly was, how it dominated any state-wide election, and how the people there weren't truly Virginian at heart. Instead, they were transplants, coming from wealthy, liberal, northeastern states and disrupting Virginia's political and economic systems.

The animosity towards Northern Virginia reflects more than just standard political divides. It is a manifestation of class and location based identities grounded in the experience of being a non-urban constituent. My participants expressed that they were powerless compared to Northern Virginia, and that the people there did not understand the needs of non-urban residents well enough to represent them. They also expressed a sense of distributive injustice based on the sharp economic divides between NoVa and the remainder of the state. While these feelings are reflective of what Katherine Cramer theorized based on her work, it is important to note that Williamsburg is not nearly as rural as the communities Cramer visited in Wisconsin. In fact, Williamsburg is a relatively wealthy locality with a significant tourism industry, college population, and shopping district. This indicates that America may not be experiencing simply a Urban vs. Rural divide, but perhaps an "Urban vs. everyone else" divide. Simply the experience of *not* being urban sets communities apart from their densely populated counterparts.

If we compound these feelings with the experiences of disrespect that my conservative participants disclose, the conservative paradox becomes perhaps less of a paradox. The narrative is this: conservative constituents find that their core values, hard work, fairness, the things that

make America *America* are violated by democratic policy, especially in cities. State and federal governments cater towards these urban centers that so often lean liberal, emphasizing housing and infrastructure, while non-urban constituents have to shout for their voices and needs to be heard (and sometimes dismissed anyways). All the while, urban Democrats are telling them, “It’s okay, just listen to us! We know what’s best for you! In fact we know so much better what you need that your beliefs are nonsensical, paradoxical even!” How can we expect anyone to lie down and take this kind of scorn? I exaggerate for effect here, but the essence remains true. While I am in no position to confirm or deny the factuality of these experiences, the point is that it *feels* this way for voters. While it may appear to an outsider that low-income, conservative voters are neglecting their own needs, in reality they are defending their way of life, their pride, and the identities they form based around the experience of being a non-urban constituent.

The sample size for this research is small, and the snowball sampling strategy I took likely means that it is not representative of the entire conservative community in Williamsburg, Virginia. I would propose that the individuals who declined to speak with me may be harboring more extreme views, or in the least more salient disdain for public institutions such as the College of William & Mary. But the takeaways ring no less true for this fact, and I propose that a focus on representativeness in sociological and political research has, in part, led to individuals feeling overlooked and powerless. The community members I spoke with reported enjoying the experience and feeling cautiously excited to see their perspectives represented. And while I myself may not agree with everything they told me, I *liked* these people. This, to me, is the most important part of work such as my own. Beyond merely continuing to develop this literature for purely academic purposes, understanding how conservative supporters' experiences manifests in their economic, geographic, and political views has potential for influencing such widespread issues such as political polarization and income inequality. Intensifying political identities, affective polarization, and general *dislike* for those with different viewpoints from our own create seemingly insurmountable barriers. Attempting to climb what Hocschild calls *the empathy wall*—a barrier to understanding across partisan divides—is crucial in mitigating polarization. It is my hope that I have scraped the surface of partisan divides and replaced feelings of anger, fear, and contempt with those of empathy, curiosity, and understanding.

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